

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Can we have our cake and eat it too? Corporate social responsibility and employees' eudaimonic well-being and performance

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Abstract

Whereas extant studies on corporate social responsibility (CSR) have documented various favorable individual outcomes, potential social effects of CSR beyond mere economic influences, such as employees' eudaimonic well-being, are often overlooked. Drawing on a sensemaking perspective, our research examines how corporate social responsibility (CSR) leads to employees' eudaimonic well-being and enhances job performance. We used three-source data covering senior managers and employees from 62 organizations to test our hypotheses. The results of the study show that CSR elicits employees' perceived meaningfulness, which in turn contributes to employees' eudaimonic well-being as well as job performance. Furthermore, we found that when CEO's humble leadership is high, CSR would function better on employees' perceived meaningfulness. Overall, this study provides a nuanced understanding of CSR by examining when and how it can simultaneously facilitate employees' eudaimonic well-being and job performance. The findings also provide important suggestions and implications for organizational sustainability.

KEYWORDS

corporate social responsibility, employee perceived meaningfulness, humble leadership, job performance, well-being

1 | INTRODUCTION

As organizations are facing increasing uncertainty from various sources, for example, the COVID-19 pandemic (Low & Bu, 2021), ways to navigate these vast challenges and ultimately achieve a win-win relationship between employees' performance and well-being have received substantial attention in both academia as well as in practice (Carnevale & Hatak, 2020; Salas-Vallina et al., 2021). While employees' performance is generally treated as the cornerstone of organizational survival, now their well-being is also being viewed as vital not only for their own further development but also for organizations' long-term success (Wood & Ogbonnaya, 2018; Wright & Huang, 2012). Thus, simultaneously enhancing employees' well-being and performance have become a pivotal issue for organizations.

Inquiries into organizational factors resulting in these mutual gains reveal corporate social responsibility (CSR) to be an influential antecedent (Glavas & Kelley, 2014; Zaman et al., 2022; Zhao et al., 2022). Despite this, our understanding of the underlying mechanisms regarding CSR and its important outcomes is far from complete. Most theoretical frameworks that prior CSR research implicitly draws on treat individuals as passive for organizational policies and practices (Jones, 2010; Rupp, 2011), ignoring their agentic role in interpreting unexpected clues and seeking meaning in a social context (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019). For example, Zhao et al. (2022) asserted that employees' responses to CSR would be seen as reciprocating to organizations' benefits. Thus, few studies illustrate how CSR stimulates employees' proactive sensemaking processes and subsequent mutual gain outcomes (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019).

We apply a sensemaking perspective to probe how CSR simultaneously affects employees' well-being and performance. A sensemaking perspective, which captures individuals to proactively seek meaning, when faced with ambiguity and uncertainty (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005), provides a pivotal theoretical foundation for this relationship. CSR is inherently related to sensemaking (Cramer et al., 2006; Nijhof & Jeurissen, 2006), as it involves some activities that are not explicitly relevant to organizations' core goals but serve as benefits for the surrounding community and even the whole world (Aguinis, 2011; Aguinis & Glavas, 2012). Since CSR demonstrates that organizations care about the mutual benefits of all stakeholders and even the planet, employees would feel more impact beyond the organizations themselves (Rosso et al., 2010; Steger et al., 2012), thus having broader interpretations of their work and finding meaningfulness at the end. This meaningfulness at work subsequently influences important outcomes (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019). Hence, drawing on a sensemaking perspective (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Weick, 1995), we suggest that employees' perceived meaningfulness is a critical mechanism. We focus specifically on eudaimonic well-being, which is more relevant to our study, as it emphasizes individual realization and fulfillment (Waterman et al., 2010).

Moreover, sensemaking is not merely a personal interpretation but also a social process that may be affected by other factors within a context (Weick et al., 2005). The extant research on CSR has dominantly emphasized managers' characteristics from the perspective of top managers, such as managerial interpretations of environmental issues (Sharma, 2000) and managers' tendency to justify unethical corporate behavior (Cullen et al., 2004). What is lacking is an examination of the boundary conditions for individuals' different evaluations of organizational CSR (Wang et al., 2016).

By building on and extending the current sensemaking framework (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019), we assert that CEOs' leadership styles, especially CEOs' humble leadership, may act as an intra-organizational sensemaking factor and play a critical role in employees' sensemaking processes because of their pronounced vision and signaling value in organizational environments (Finkelstein et al., 2009). Humble leadership is defined as the extent to which leaders have accurate self-awareness, appreciate others' strengths, and set self-transcendent pursuits (Ou et al., 2014). A humble CEO reflects an ethical orientation of organizations rather than a self-interested and economic-only focus (Frostenson, 2016) by emphasizing lower levels of self-focus

and prioritizing the common good (Kesebir, 2014; Ou et al., 2018). Such CEOs care more about employees' welfare and social benefits of the surrounding community and pursue self-transcendent goals concerning the greater whole (Owens et al., 2013), which is consistent with the nature of CSR. These characteristics regarding humble leadership would further facilitate employees' positive sensemaking toward CSR (Donia & Sirsly, 2016), which in turn boosts employees' meaningfulness at work. Hence, CEOs' humble leadership could be a critical boundary condition for CSR to motivate employees to find meaningfulness at work.

In summary, the present study examines how and when organizational CSR affects both employees' eudaimonic well-being and job performance. Our study makes several theoretical contributions. First, by examining a specific social-based outcome (i.e., well-being) rather than economic effects, we extend the extant micro-level CSR research. We also go a step further and examine employees' eudaimonic well-being in conjunction with their job performance to illuminate how CSR leads to win-win results. Second, drawing on a sensemaking perspective (Weick et al., 2005), we utilize meaningfulness as an intermediary linking organizational CSR and employees' eudaimonic well-being and job performance. Meaningful work has become an ethical issue, and organizations need to fulfill an ethical obligation in providing employees with a sense of meaningfulness (Lysova et al., 2019). Thus, we consider different organization-level factors that may affect meaningfulness, contributing to the literature on meaningful work. Third, our study provides a more in-depth understanding of contingencies concerning CSR functioning. Specifically, we identify CEOs' humble leadership as a specific intraorganizational sensemaking factor, thus answering calls for more inquiries into CSR-related situational moderators that are currently understudied (Gond et al., 2017). Finally, our multilevel analysis of CSR provides novel insights by unpacking the process through which organizational CSR leads to employees' evaluations and important outcomes (i.e., employees' well-being and performance) (Robertson & Barling, 2013; Wang et al., 2016). Whereas CSR is conceptually multilevel in scope, CSR research at multiple levels is still scarce in the current literature (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Jamali et al., 2020). Using a multilevel design, this study offers a nuanced but holistic view that advances the current CSR and sustainability research. Figure 1 presents our theoretical model.

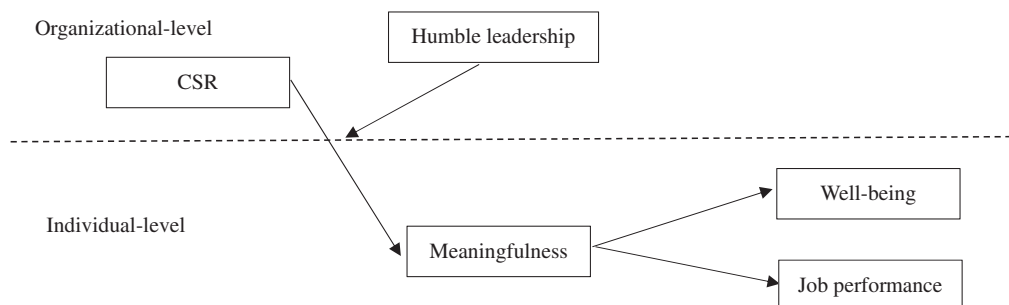


FIGURE 1 The theoretical model

2 | THEORY AND HYPOTHESES

2.1 | CSR and employees' perceived meaningfulness

CSR refers to organizational policies that focus on multiple stakeholders' benefits (Aguinis, 2011). CSR focuses not only on the business value of organizations but also on important outcomes extending beyond financial results (Wang et al., 2016), such as customer satisfaction (Conlon & Murray, 1996) and organizational attractiveness for job seekers (Jones et al., 2014). Thus, the implicit and explicit prosocial values of CSR make it an influential factor in enabling employees to experience meaningfulness at work (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Tourigny et al., 2019).

A sensemaking perspective provides a theoretical rationale for explaining the effect of organizational CSR on employees' experiences of meaningfulness. Sensemaking originates from the idea that individuals tend to assign meaning to specific issues or events when they encounter ambiguity and complexity to clarify and interpret their surroundings (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005). As Weick et al. (2005) highlighted, the above-mentioned ambiguity and uncertainty are the two reasons for stimulating individuals' sensemaking process.

We argue that organizational CSR motivates employees' sensemaking processes and ultimately fosters their meaningfulness at work. First, CSR involves some degree of ambiguity and complexity (Cramer et al., 2006), which leads employees to make sense of it. Although CSR demonstrates that organizations or corporate decision-makers are concerned about social welfare within or outside the organization (Farooq et al., 2017), it is also related to addressing diverging but interconnected demands from all stakeholders (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Hahn et al., 2014). Indeed, organizations may often confront tradeoffs between different-directed CSR, such as self- and others-directed CSR (Bridoux et al., 2016). Thus, in the eyes of the employees, CSR would be an ambiguous clue that needs meaning to be derived out of it.

Second, CSR is accompanied by unexpectedness and uncertainty (Cramer et al., 2006; Nijhof & Jeurissen, 2006), enhancing employees' sensemaking processes. CSR implies that organizations are concerned about social welfare beyond economic thinking, such as the community and even the whole planet (El Akremi et al., 2018). In the business frame, the acknowledgment of organizations' economic benefits is the primary objective (Hahn et al., 2014) while implementing CSR activities can be considered an unexpected event for employees. Moreover, incorporating CSR as critical organizational policy demonstrates what companies value the most (Nijhof & Jeurissen, 2006). In this case, employees are more likely to deploy sensemaking to make better value judgments regarding CSR.

These sensemaking processes related to CSR may then help employees find meaningfulness at work, which is defined as ones' perceptions of value or purpose with respect to their work (May et al., 2004). On the one hand, CSR expands employees' perceptions of their work impact satisfies their inherent needs for significance

and purpose (Rosso et al., 2010), and facilitates meaningfulness by implying that employees' work contributes to others' well-being and interests. According to the literature, meaningfulness derives not only from work but also from the social impact and worth that arise from contributing to the social good (Bauman & Skitka, 2012; Lysova et al., 2019). Furthermore, individuals can also experience meaningfulness when they think that their work has a more significant social benefit (Steger et al., 2012). In their comprehensive review of meaningfulness, Rosso et al. (2010) suggested that when individuals perceive their work as essential to the society or their community, they are likely to acquire meaningfulness. On the other hand, CSR practices reflect organizations' ethical conduct concerning various stakeholders that may bolster organizational prestige (Glavas & Kelley, 2014). The positive perceptions of organizations resulting from CSR, such as organizational prestige and employees' pride due to an ethical image of the organization (Maignan et al., 1999), are likely to motivate employees to become more involved in their jobs and ultimately find more meaningfulness (Brown, 1996). Indeed, several conceptual and empirical studies provide evidence that CSR is positively related to employees' perceived meaningfulness (Akdoğan et al., 2016; Glavas & Kelley, 2014; Raub & Blunschi, 2014). For example, in their multilevel review, Lysova et al. (2019) noted that organizational practices, such as CSR, have the potential to affect employees' perceived meaningfulness.

Hypothesis 1 *Organizational CSR positively affects employees' perceived meaningfulness.*

2.2 | Employees' perceived meaningfulness and eudaimonic well-being

Meaningful work has been increasingly emphasized by scholars from diverse disciplines, including business ethics, psychology, and sociology (Michaelson et al., 2014). In the business ethics area, meaningful work has generally developed as a moral topic pertaining to multiple perspectives (Lips-Wiersma et al., 2020). The "meaningfulness of work" denotes the significance individuals ascribe to their work (Pratt & Ashforth, 2003). Therefore, meaningfulness is a subjective experience or evaluation of work rather than an objective characteristic (Allan et al., 2019).

We first propose that when individuals perceive meaningfulness, they experience more well-being. In this study, we focus on eudaimonic well-being, which is more relevant to meaningfulness than other forms of well-being (Rothausen & Henderson, 2019). In contrast to subjective well-being, eudaimonic well-being is rooted in philosophical understandings of eudaimonia (Waterman, 1993), which emphasizes the realization of one's potential and the value of the eudaimonic activity itself rather than mere subjective experiences of pleasure (Ryan & Deci, 2001). Thus, because finding meaning and deriving greater meaningfulness are "fundamental human motives" (Arnold et al., 2007; Britt et al., 2001), employees' initial needs may be satisfied when they experience meaningfulness at

work. These satisfied needs, in turn, lead to employees' well-being (Deci & Ryan, 2000). Self-determination theory also demonstrates that the satisfaction of basic needs influences personal growth and fosters well-being (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Moreover, when employees perceive meaningfulness, they recognize that their work is significant to themselves and others. Under such conditions, they may dedicate more effort to their work, ultimately facilitating their self-realization and well-being at work (Demirtas et al., 2017). Indeed, previous research has documented a positive relationship between experiences of meaningfulness and well-being (Rothausen & Henderson, 2019).

Hypothesis 2 *Employees' perceived meaningfulness positively affects employees' well-being.*

Furthermore, we suggest that employees' perceived meaningfulness can be an important mediator. As mentioned above, organizational CSR demonstrates that organizations care about others' interests and the common good. From a sensemaking perspective (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005), employees may interpret these environmental cues from CSR, make sense of them, and perceive more meaningfulness. Subsequently, employees will experience greater well-being as they realize their potential and fulfill their need for personal expressiveness.

Hypothesis 3 *Employees' perceived meaningfulness mediates the positive relationship between CSR and employees' well-being.*

2.3 | Employees' perceived meaningfulness and job performance

In addition, we posit that employees' experience of meaningfulness is positively related to job performance. First, meaningful work is a key motivator of individual job performance (Michaelson, 2005). From a cognitive perspective, employees who have greater meaningfulness may exhibit more intrinsic work motivation and commitment to organizations (Hackman & Oldham, 1980; Thomas & Velthouse, 1990), which, in turn, are expected to increase their engagement in their work (May et al., 2004). This engagement can contribute to job performance. Kahn (1990) asserted that psychological meaningfulness is an important condition that affects how individuals engage in their work. Allan et al. (2019) also found that meaningfulness predicts job satisfaction, commitment and engagement, which subsequently affects performance. Second, from an emotional perspective, meaningfulness elicits positive emotions toward one's work or organization. These positive emotions enable employees to make full use of the resources they possess and even broaden their mindsets (Soane et al., 2013). As a result, they seek information to improve their work, make beneficial suggestions for workplace functioning, and facilitate organizational processes (Fürstenberg et al., 2021). Empirical evidence has also shown the link between meaningfulness and employee performance. For example, Walumbwa et al. (2019) found that employees' meaningfulness is a

key mediator of the service climate and employees' service performance. Frieder et al. (2018) suggested that if employees perceive meaningfulness at work, their job performance will be enhanced.

Hypothesis 4 *Employees' perceived meaningfulness positively affects job performance.*

We also posit that CSR can promote employees' job performance through employees' perceived meaningfulness. A sensemaking perspective suggests that individuals tend to construct meaning and make interpretations about the ambiguities and complexities they encounter, which ultimately affect important outcomes (Weick, 1995). As noted above, CSR provides a significant cue for employees to engage in the sensemaking process. In other words, CSR enhances employees' perceptions of value, significance, and purpose by contributing to the interests of others. Employees who gain this sense of meaningfulness are likely to have the cognitive and emotional resources to dedicate more effort to their work (May et al., 2004; Soane et al., 2013), thereby improving their job performance. Thus, CSR contributes to employees' perceived meaningfulness and, in turn, job performance.

Hypothesis 5 *Employees' perceived meaningfulness mediates the positive relationship between CSR and job performance.*

2.4 | The moderating role of CEOs' humble leadership

Sensemaking is a social process through which individuals are embedded in a context and influenced by others (Allport, 1985; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014). Leaders, especially CEOs, may act as a primary sensemaking factor that affects employees' CSR sensemaking process through their signaling visions and values within an organization (Finkelstein et al., 2009). We specifically focus on CEOs' humble leadership and suggest that it may strengthen the relationship between CSR and employees' meaningfulness for two reasons.

First, humble CEOs tend to have sufficient self-knowledge and self-awareness (Owens & Hekman, 2012) and acknowledge that several things are more significant than themselves (Ou et al., 2014), which is consistent with the idea of CSR (Wang et al., 2020). Humble people believe they are not the center of the universe and that the larger community and society are more important than themselves (Ou et al., 2018). When CEOs are humble, their low "self-focused" initiatives are in line with the "others-focused" intent of CSR (Wang et al., 2020). This, in turn, enhances the value of CSR in employees' sensemaking process and subsequently perceived meaningfulness.

Second, humble CEOs are more likely to set self-transcendent visions and strive to contribute to the greater good (Ou et al., 2014). These inclinations cause them to pursue more social welfare, moral rules, and even universal truths rather than act in a materialistic manner (Kesebir, 2014). Such signals are in line with the inherent positive motives pertaining to organizational CSR (Wang et al., 2020). As noted earlier, CEOs' humble leadership not only enable them to take

the common good seriously but also tends to lead them to take action toward these relevant goals (Ou et al., 2018). Thus, this behavior would also promote employees' sensemaking of CSR and lead them to find greater meaningfulness at work.

The opposite happens when CEOs are less humble, in which case they are more likely to focus on themselves and emphasize their superiority or entitlement (Davis et al., 2011). This may result in self-serving situations contrary to the inherent nature of organizational CSR. When CEOs' humble leadership is low, the self comes first, and their glory and interests are prioritized in the pursuits list. This results in less emphasis on the greater good when setting goals and taking actions (Ou et al., 2018). In these contexts, CEOs' low-level humble leadership interferes with employees' sensemaking of CSR for their work.

Hypothesis 6 *The positive relationship between CSR and employees' meaningfulness would be stronger when CEOs' humble leadership is higher.*

Furthermore, we propose a moderated mediation model. When CEOs are humbler, employees may gain more consistent information or environmental cues from the sensemaking process pertaining to organizational CSR, which increases employees' sense of meaningfulness and, ultimately, employees' well-being and job performance.

Hypothesis 7a *CEOs' humble leadership strengthens the indirect effect of CSR on employees' well-being through meaningfulness.*

Hypothesis 7b *CEOs' humble leadership strengthens the indirect effect of CSR on employees' job performance through meaningfulness.*

3 | METHODOLOGY

3.1 | Sample and procedure

Data were collected from 81 organizations located in north, central, and southeast China. These organizations are engaged in a variety of sectors, including manufacturing, services, high-tech industries, and so on. With the support of local governments and alumni of a famous university in China, we contacted the CEOs of these organizations, explained this study, and assured them of data confidentiality measures. We then asked each CEO to designate an HR manager to assist us with the data collection process. The HR managers were asked to follow a one-page guide and distribute unique questionnaires to corresponding respondents to ensure the quality of data. When the respondents completed their surveys, they were given a blank envelope to seal their questionnaires. Finally, the HR managers collected all the responses and sent them to us.

We collected data from three sources: two senior managers and corresponding employees in each organization. One senior

manager (senior manager [A]) reported on organizational CSR and firm size, and the other senior manager (senior manager [B]) rated the CEO's humble leadership. Employees reported their feelings of meaningfulness and well-being, job performance, gender, age, education, and tenure. Our initial sample consisted of 81 senior managers (A), 81 senior managers (B), and 964 employees. The final sample included 62 senior managers (A), 62 senior managers (B), and 661 matched employees after removing void and unpaired questionnaires. The response rates of senior managers (A), senior managers (B), and employees were 76.5%, 76.5%, and 68.6%, respectively. Regarding organizational size, 4.9% had fewer than 50 employees, 6.6% had 50–100 employees, 32.8% had 101–500 employees, 16.4% had 501–1000 employees, 13.1% had 1001–2000 employees, and 26.2% had more than 2001 employees. In terms of employees, 51.8% were male, and 48.2% were female; 1.7% were under 20 years old, 20.3% were 21–25 years old, 30.3% were 26–30 years old, 24.8% were 31–35 years old, 10.3% were 36–40 years old, 7.1% were 41–45 years old, 3.8% were 46–50 years old, 1.3% were 51–55 years old, and 0.3% were 56–60 years old. In total, 85% of the employees had a college degree. The average working tenure was 53.71 months. Regarding sectoral classification of organizations, there were 2 energy organizations, 3 real estate organizations, 4 service organizations, 17 high-tech organizations, 4 finance organizations, 5 retail organizations, and 27 manufacturing organizations.

3.2 | Measures

3.2.1 | CSR

We measured CSR using 17 items from Turker (2009) that have been validated by multiple empirical studies, including Farooq et al. (2017). Senior managers (A) reported on organizational CSR using a 7-point Likert scale. An instance of an item is, "Our company participates in activities that aim to protect and improve the quality of the natural environment." The coefficient alpha was 0.949.

3.2.2 | Employees' perceived meaningfulness

We measured meaningfulness using May et al.'s (2004) 6-item scale. Employees rated their levels of perceived meaningfulness on items like "I feel that the work I do on my job is valuable." The coefficient alpha was 0.925.

3.2.3 | Well-being

We measured well-being with Waterman et al.'s (2010) 21-item scale. Employees rated their well-being on items such as "When I engage in activities that involve my best potential, I have a sense of really being alive." The corresponding alpha coefficient was 0.840.

3.2.4 | Job performance

We measured job performance with Tsui et al.'s (1997) 6-item measure. Employees reported their job performance. An example of an item is, "The quality of work is much higher than average." The coefficient alpha was 0.930.

3.2.5 | CEO humble leadership

Senior manager (B) provided their CEO's humble leadership with Ou et al.'s (2014) 18-item scale. An instance of an item is, "My CEO actively seeks feedback, even if it is critical." The coefficient alpha was 0.895.

3.2.6 | Control variables

Employees' gender, age, education, and tenure were controlled because they are linked to job performance and well-being (Frieder et al., 2018; Riordan et al., 2003). At the organization level, we controlled for firm size.

3.3 | Analyses

We used multilevel structural equation modeling (MSEM) to test our model using Mplus7.4. Before we tested all our hypotheses, a multilevel confirmatory factor analysis (MCFA) was conducted to verify the distinctive validity of the variables, i.e., CSR, CEOs' humble leadership, and employees' perceived meaningfulness, well-being, and job performance. Following recommendations by Bentler and Chou (1987), we used item parceling for all the variables since the ratio of the sample size to the indicators was less than 5. We then ran the null models to estimate the between-variances of level-1 variables (well-being, job performance, and employees' perceived meaningfulness) for multilevel modeling. The results showed that the ICCs (1) for well-being, job performance, and employees' perceived meaningfulness were 0.187, 0.228, and 0.099, respectively, suggesting the need for multilevel analysis. We used grand-mean centering methods for variables at the organization level and group-mean centering methods for variables at the individual level (Hofmann & Gavin, 1998). We also employed a Monte Carlo method with R software to estimate the 95% confidence interval (CI) to examine indirect effects.

4 | RESULTS

Descriptive statistics and correlations for all variables are presented in Table 1. Table 2 reports the multilevel CFA results. The results showed that the five-factor model, which included CSR, humble leadership, meaningfulness, well-being and job

TABLE 1 Descriptive statistics and correlations

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Cronbach's alpha	AVE	CR
1. Gender	1.48	0.50													
2. Age	3.67	1.49	-0.01												
3. Education	2.36	0.79	0.07	-0.21 ^{**}											
4. Tenure	53.71	61.07	0.04	0.52 ^{**}	-0.19 ^{**}										
5. Firm size	3.98	1.53	0.03	-0.17 ^{**}	0.05	0.06									
6. CSR	6.32	0.70	-0.01	-0.07	0.01	0.13 ^{**}	0.30 ^{**}						0.949	0.573	0.957
7. Meaningfulness	6.05	0.90	0.00	0.06	0.07	0.04	-0.09 [*]	0.13 ^{**}					0.925	0.758	0.926
8. Well-being	4.97	0.73	0.02	0.10 ^{**}	0.09 [*]	0.03	-0.08 [*]	0.08 [*]	0.63 ^{**}				0.840	0.378	0.925
9. Job performance	5.10	0.93	-0.06	0.11 ^{**}	0.06	0.05	-0.08 [*]	0.03	0.32 ^{**}	0.35 ^{**}			0.930	0.783	0.947
10. Humble leadership	5.81	0.70	0.07	-0.09 [*]	-0.04	0.01	-0.05	0.06	-0.07	-0.05	-0.06		0.895	0.534	0.953

Notes: N = 62 organizations. n = 661 employees.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$.

TABLE 2 Results of CFA

Model	χ^2	df	CFI	NNFI	RMSEA	SRMR (within)	SRMR (between)
Hypothesized model	33.318	32	0.999	0.999	0.007	0.015	0.031
Alternative Model 1 (Meaningfulness and Job performance combined)	975.895	34	0.739	0.609	0.194	0.174	0.031
Alternative Model 2 (CSR and Humble leadership combined)	126.566	33	0.974	0.960	0.062	0.015	0.284
Alternative Model 3 (Meaningfulness, Job performance and well-being combined; CSR and Humble leadership combined)	1518.924	36	0.589	0.418	0.236	0.180	0.284

Notes: $N = 62$ organizations. $n = 661$ employees.

TABLE 3 The results of multilevel path analysis

Variables	Meaningfulness	Well-being	Job performance
Intercept	6.21*** (.06)	1.32** (.51)	2.29*** (.65)
<i>Individual-level</i>			
Gender		0.04 (.05)	-0.11 (.07)
Age		0.04 (.02)	0.08* (.03)
Education		0.05 (.03)	0.04 (.04)
Tenure		-0.00 (.00)	0.00 (.00)
Meaningfulness		0.47*** (.03)	0.28*** (.05)
<i>Organization-level</i>			
Firm size	-0.05 (.05)	-0.01 (.02)	0.00 (.03)
CSR	0.25** (.08)		
Humble leadership	-0.20* (.09)		
Meaningfulness		0.57*** (.08)	0.43*** (.10)
<i>Interaction</i>			
CSR × Humble leadership	0.23** (.09)		

Notes: $N = 62$ organizations. $n = 661$ employees.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

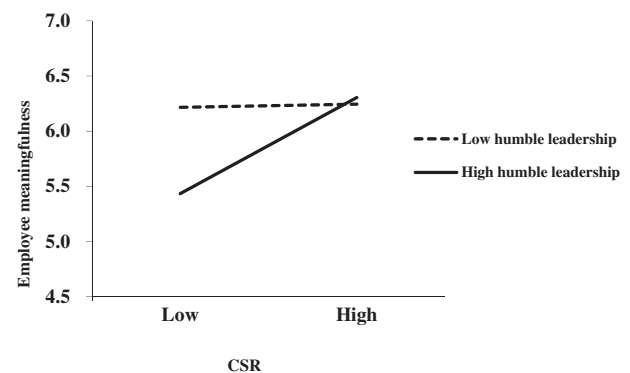


FIGURE 3 The moderating role of humble leadership

performance, fitted the data best ($\chi^2 = 33.318$, RMSEA = 0.007, SRMR for within = 0.015, SRMR for between = 0.031, CFI = 0.999, NNFI = 0.999). This finding demonstrated that these variables had discriminant validity. Table 3 and Figure 2 show the results of the multilevel path analysis.

As shown in Table 3 and Figure 2, CSR was associated with employees' perceived meaningfulness ($\gamma = 0.25$, $p < .01$). Thus, Hypothesis 1 was supported.

In Hypothesis 2, employees' meaningfulness was hypothesized to be positively related to employees' well-being. The results showed

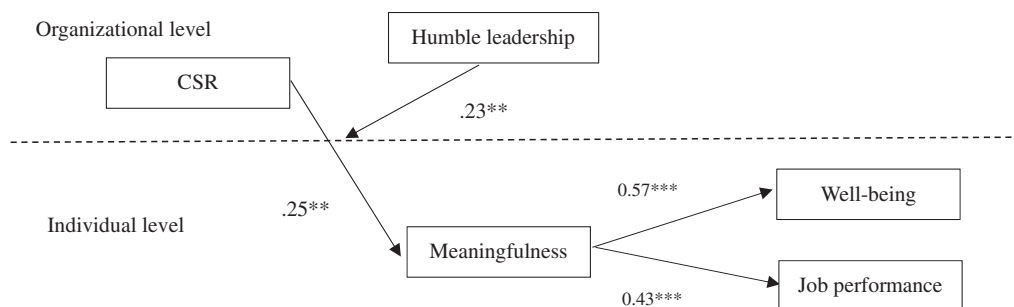


FIGURE 2 The results of multilevel path analysis

that employees' meaningfulness was associated with an increase in employees' well-being ($\gamma = 0.57, p < .001$).

Hypothesis 3 postulated that CSR increases employees' well-being through their meaningfulness. To test the indirect effect of CSR on employees' well-being, we multiplied the two path coefficients from CSR to employees' meaningfulness and from employees' meaningfulness to employees' well-being. CSR was seen to have a positive indirect effect on employees' well-being via employees' meaningfulness ($effect = 0.143, p < .01$). Following the recommendations of Preacher et al. (2011) and MacKinnon et al. (2004), we used the Monte Carlo method to estimate the 95% confidence interval with R software. The 95% CI was [0.05, 0.25] and did not include zero, supporting Hypothesis 3.

Similarly, Hypothesis 4 suggested that employees' meaningfulness would lead to higher job performance. Table 3 and Figure 2 show that employees' meaningfulness significantly affects job performance ($\gamma = 0.43, p < .001$), supporting Hypothesis 4. In addition, Hypothesis 5 stated that CSR increases employees' job performance via employees' meaningfulness. The results indicated that CSR has a positive indirect effect on employees' job performance via employees' meaningfulness ($effect = 0.108, p < .01$). Moreover, the 95% CI was [0.03, 0.19], excluding zero.

In terms of the moderating role of CEOs' humble leadership, the results presented in Table 3 and Figure 2 suggest that the interaction term was significant ($\gamma = 0.23, p < .01$). When CEOs display high ($\gamma = 0.41, p < .001$) rather than low levels of humble leadership ($\gamma = 0.09, ns$), CSR would lead to more employees' meaningfulness (see Figure 3). Thus, Hypothesis 6 was supported.

In addition, Hypothesis 7a posited that when CEOs exhibit more humble leadership, CSR contributes to employees' well-being via meaningfulness. We used the Monte Carlo method to estimate conditional indirect effects when CEOs' humble leadership is high or low. The results showed that when CEOs are humbler, CSR has a stronger indirect effect on employee well-being ($effect = 0.236, p < .01$; 95% CI = [0.11, 0.38]). In contrast, when CEOs are less humble, CSR has a weaker indirect effect on employee well-being ($effect = 0.049, ns$; 95% CI = [-0.05, 0.17]). The difference was also significant ($effect = 0.187, p < .01$; 95% CI = [0.05, 0.33]). Therefore, Hypothesis 7a was supported.

Similarly, Hypothesis 7b suggested that when CEOs' humble leadership is high, the indirect effect is stronger. We also tested the conditional indirect effects of CSR on employees' job performance through meaningfulness. The Monte Carlo method was performed to estimate the 95% confidence intervals. The results indicated that the indirect effect of CSR on employee job performance through meaningfulness with high levels of CEOs' humble leadership was more positive ($effect = 0.179, p < .01$; 95% CI = [0.07, 0.31]) than that under low levels of CEOs' humble leadership ($effect = 0.037, ns$; 95% CI = [-0.05, 0.12]). The difference was also significant ($effect = 0.142, p < .01$; 95% CI = [0.03, 0.28]). Therefore, Hypothesis 7b was supported.

5 | DISCUSSION

Although prior CSR research has examined substantial individuals' outcomes, most studies still primarily emphasize the business value of CSR in terms of employee outcomes (Aguinis & Glavas, 2012, 2019), and little is known about whether it can promote potential social outcomes, such as employee well-being. Moreover, extant examinations of the underlying mechanisms have focused predominantly on individuals' reactive responses (Rupp, 2011; Zhao et al., 2022), rather than their agentic role in meaning-seeking. To address these research gaps, we examine whether, how, and when CSR can contribute to both employees' well-being and job performance by drawing on a sensemaking perspective. Based on three-source data from 62 senior managers (A), 62 senior managers (B), and 661 employees, we found that CSR contributes to employees' well-being and job performance by enhancing employees' perceived meaningfulness. These findings are in line with previous research on CSR and individual performance. Indeed, Story and Neves (2015) found that CSR enhances employees' task performance. Thus, our study complements the current CSR literature by highlighting the importance of CSR on employees' well-being and the win-win results. Moreover, the results revealed that when CEOs' humble leadership is high, CSR would be more effective in promoting employees' perceived meaningfulness and subsequent well-being and job performance. These findings align with increasing research on the influence of leadership styles on the CSR implementations, such as transformational leadership (Du et al., 2013). Beyond this, our findings on the specific role of CEOs' humble leadership demonstrate consistent information clues with CSR.

5.1 | Theoretical contributions

First, our study integrates the effects of CSR on employees' well-being and job performance into a model. Prior research on the outcomes of CSR has focused predominately on well-established concepts that are generally related to business value and management efficiencies (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Zaman et al., 2022), such as employees' organizational identification (Kim et al., 2010) and retention (Jones, 2010). However, some outcomes that are specifically related to CSR remain understudied. For example, employees' well-being, which captures the intrinsic interests of employees, is conceptually relevant to the core nature of CSR, yet it is overlooked in the current micro-CSR literature. Moreover, as lamented by Aguinis and Glavas (2019), CSR research largely pursues the explicit advantage of achieving business goals, increased productivity, and increased financial influence. Thus, we echo the calls for more inquiries into how CSR affects employees' well-being to extend beyond financial outcomes. We contend that CSR can shape both employees' well-being and job performance.

Second, drawing on a sensemaking perspective, this study identifies employees' perceived meaningfulness as the key mechanism

and thus extends existing theoretical frameworks explaining the effects of CSR on important outcomes. Whereas most CSR research has focused on individual outcomes on the basis of social exchange theory (Mallory & Rupp, 2014; Zhao et al., 2022), justice theory (Rupp, 2011), and social identity theory (De Roeck & Delobbe, 2012; Jones, 2010), these theoretical perspectives implicitly treat individuals as passive respondents when organizational practices are implemented. However, prior research has neglected individuals' agentic role in making sense of surrounding environmental clues, especially when faced with ambiguity and uncertainty (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019). Thus, applying a sensemaking perspective to the CSR literature, we illustrate employees' proactive sensemaking toward CSR by identifying employee-experienced meaningfulness as a critical mediator. Moreover, this study also extends employees' sensemaking by focusing on CSR, which is beyond their own work experience. Given that the nature of work is typically job-related and intra-organizational (Rosso et al., 2010), our examination of organizational CSR demonstrates the importance of emphasizing the relationships between other stakeholders, such as the larger communities.

Third, our study integrates leadership with CSR research and illuminates the moderating role of CEOs' humble leadership. Regarding the CSR literature, Gond et al. (2017) lamented that little focus had been devoted to the boundary conditions of CSR reactions. We heed the call for research on CSR-related moderators (Zhao et al., 2022) and show that when CEOs' humble leadership is high, CSR will result in more employees' perceived meaningfulness and ultimate employees' well-being as well as job performance. In doing so, we offer a nuanced understanding of the process by which organizational CSR is interpreted, evaluated, and made sense of by employees. With respect to employees' sensemaking, our study also highlights the pivotal role of CEOs' humble leadership, which acts as a crucial sensemaking factor in an organization, in accounting for significant variability in how employees perceive CSR. Moreover, increasing research has begun to illustrate the functioning of leadership in CSR implementation, such as transformational leadership (Du et al., 2013). Despite this, little research has illustrated the role of humble leadership, which connotes more others-focused and caring for the social good. Accordingly, our study adds more clarity to the role of leadership style in deriving CSR-related benefits.

Finally, while it is well established that CSR is a multilevel phenomenon (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Jamali et al., 2020), CSR has predominantly been studied and examined at single levels (Aguinis & Glavas, 2012). Specifically, prior research on CSR has primarily paid attention to the macro-level (i.e., the institutional or organizational level) (Bansal & Song, 2017). Recently, micro-CSR research using a person-centric approach has begun to pivot from a focus on the macro-level to the micro-level (i.e., the individual level) (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Gond et al., 2017; Jones & Rupp, 2017). What is still relatively lacking is a multilevel consolidation of the entire CSR implementation process (Tourigny et al., 2019), including how CSR is implemented at the organizational level and how it subsequently impacts employees' perceptions, evaluations, and reactions at the individual level. In this study, we, therefore, integrate a sensemaking

framework including multilevel sensemaking factors with the current CSR literature and develop a multilevel model to reveal how CSR affects employees' sensemaking across hierarchical levels.

5.2 | Managerial implications

First, enhancing employees' well-being and performance simultaneously has been devoted substantive attention by practitioners, especially in today's VUCA context. Thus, identifying key antecedents of the win-win results is important for scholars and managers alike. The results suggest that CSR has become an influential factor contributing to both employees' well-being and job performance. Thus, highlighting CSR provides an avenue for organizational managers to utilize CSR as an effective approach to achieving mutual gains. Accordingly, managers are encouraged to enhance the engagement and visibility of organizational CSR for employees through various practices, for example, implementing multiple CSR activities, providing training programs involving the organizational CSR introduction section, and increasing CSR-related promotion within the organization.

Second, meaningful work has become an ethical issue that pertains to multiple perspectives, including organizational perspectives on fulfilling ethical obligations to support employees' meaningful work. Our findings demonstrate that enhanced meaningfulness is conducive to employees' well-being and performance. Thus, organizations can promote multiple activities that enhance employees' perceived meaningfulness. For example, organizations can select employees who have high fitness with organizational missions, provide employees with some degree of proactive job design authority, and cultivate collaborative and friendly relationships among employees to increase employees' identification.

Third, sensemaking factors at various levels, including the organizational and individual levels, matter to the employee sensemaking process. Our study suggests that humble leadership strengthens the functioning of CSR on employees' sensemaking processes. When CEOs are humbler, organizational CSR is more likely to promote employees' perceived meaningfulness at work. Thus, organizations should encourage managers at different levels to cultivate humble leadership, for instance, giving them some rewards when attending executive coaching programs for humble leadership and displaying humble leadership at work. In addition, organizations can take humility into account in the selection process of managers. More generally, managers should consider both internal and external factors that may affect the effectiveness of CSR, such as organizational climate. By doing so, managers can better navigate CSR implementation.

5.3 | Limitations and future research

First, although our data were from three sources (i.e., senior managers (A), senior managers (B), and employees) to reduce common

method bias, the data were cross-sectional. Future studies could apply multisource and multi-wave research designs to validate our theoretical model further. Second, our framework examined only the moderating role of CEOs' humble leadership. Other sensemaking factors related to employees, such as employees' moral identities and CSR organizational support (Zhao et al., 2022), could also affect the extent to which CSR influences important outcomes. Future studies could consider more sensemaking factors at different levels of the process. Finally, this study did not examine alternative key mechanisms to test the added value of employees' meaningfulness, which is identified as the key mediator between CSR and well-being/job performance. Researchers are encouraged to integrate these fragmented mechanisms to examine their varied effects, which may provide an in-depth understanding of the mediating mechanisms.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST

There are no conflicts of interest to declare.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Given confidential contracts with surveyed organizations, the data are not available.

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